

The bias of buying

Surprised? Believe me, we all were too. This is probably the first time in years that Robert is officially on leave and not writing the editorial. He's often said before, "Jobs you take breaks from, passions you can't". This time though, he has a new preoccupation in his life that he's equally passionate about – his newborn baby boy. The proud daddy even sent us his son's specifications in a group chat to the team. "Boy, 3.11kg. Healthy," it cryptically said. Now that you guys know, please send him the cheesiest congratulatory messages you can think of. My life expectancy will be drastically cut short as a result but still, totally worth it!

Now moving on to filling some really big shoes.

Every year around this time, we do a buying special in anticipation of the Diwali shopping frenzy. To aid you in your quest of buying the right gadgets, we give you the most up-to-date buying advice for all of the product categories we cover. In theory, reading it will save you your hard earned cash. But are we creatures of pure logic when it comes to buying technology? Do we go with cold hard facts? Those are some questions I wish to address here.

The human mind is a powerful machine. But within its infinite wisdom and teraflops of processing power are lodged several logical fallacies and cognitive biases that make us irrational, bungling idiots. Simply put, there are glitches in our reasoning abilities that lead us to make rash decisions and arrive at the wrong conclusions.

Let me explain.

Being in the technology space, all of us here at Digit constantly get queries from within our friend circles seeking buying advice. "Should I buy XYZ phone?" or "Is XYZ tablet practical for my mom?" As Digit readers, most of you must be deemed gadget gurus in your own right within your groups, and may find yourselves at the receiving end of similar questions. When such queries come to us, there are times when we need to tell our friends, "For your needs I think you should go for PQR". And the moment we do, they look deflated. Forlorn, they persist, "But isn't XYZ good?"

What you have right there is 'confirmation bias' – a tendency to seek out only those perspectives that reaffirm our pre-existing views. Your friends have already made up their

minds. All they want you to do is agree. We do this in our day-to-day lives as well, seeking out only those cliques with whom our views match perfectly. During the hunter-gatherer days, this behaviour had an evolutionary advantage; but today, in the concrete jungle, when it trickles down into buying decisions, it's simply your mind playing tricks on you.

Another one of these tricks is the 'status-quo bias'. This bias has its roots in the tendency of people to oppose change. We're creatures of routine in our regular lives and even when it comes to buying objects, we do the same things over and over. Familiar products are preferred over highly recommended products. I've come across so many people lapping up Windows-based Nokia phones simply because they associate it with Nokia in its good old days, believing perhaps falsely, that their phones can still be run over, dropped and shattered, and be assembled back to work like the 3310.

Fanboys – another cognitive anomaly – rave and rant in rabid support of a product or company even when facts point to a different story. Researchers have found that ownership of a product (and in turn its associated ideology) adds emotional value to things – i.e. the 'endowment effect'. The 'choice supportive bias', on the other hand, makes your mind justify your irrational purchase so as to not cause cognitive dissonance, in this case, buyer's remorse. If you know anyone who has invested in \$1,000 audiophile-grade headphones, ask them if they think their purchase was worthwhile. Chances are they'll defend their stand a little too aggressively. That's classic choice supportive bias.

You're probably wondering why I'm dispensing this short lesson on psychology. The point is: no matter how much buying advice you read, if you're not aware of these biases your subconscious has built up over an entire lifetime, you'll be prone to making the wrong choices. Knowing about cognitive biases and fallacies has been known to mitigate their effects at least to a certain extent. So the next time you're drawn to a particular brand or product, analyse why that behaviour is being triggered. Once you do, and realise for example that you want the iPhone 5S simply because it's a status symbol, by all means go ahead and buy it. Just don't try to justify your purchase as a purely logical one. 



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